my very first day in Kolkata. When I took the call, he informed me in a slightly aggrieved tone that his posting had just come in, to proceed to the OTA, Gaya as the Commandant. I gave an incredulous chuckle. On my first day of taking over the Command, my COS was posted out. I had to assure the COS, who was quite upset, that I myself was flabbergasted at this development, of which I had no inkling. Having been a COS myself, I knew how important the role of the COS was. Since the outgoing and incoming Army Commanders do not meet each other, it was the COS who provided the continuity and was the principal adviser. It took me most of the remaining evening to explain to the COS the circumstances under which I had moved, not even having had time to go to the MO Dte for the detailed briefing, let alone anything else. I do not know if he was convinced, but I was certainly surprised at the turn of events and how the top two positions were being turned over nearly simultaneously. As it is, barely had I taken over, than I had to dine out my COS. After that, I remained without a COS for almost six months, severely hampering my functioning, until the post was filled by Lt Gen RP Kalita.[2]

Due to its vast area of operations, the touring was extensive. Moreover, as military aircraft did not have permission to overfly Bangladesh, any routing to Dimapur or Tezpur had to go around through the Siliguri corridor, staying in Indian air space throughout. This almost doubled the time taken to reach either of these Corps HQ locations. Since helicopter flying was restricted to the morning hours, especially in the HAA, it meant one had to reach the previous evening to be able to make an early morning start. Even then, given the vagaries of the weather, there was no guarantee that the scheduled plan would go through fully as planned. There was always a plan A and a plan B. On one occasion, having spent three hours in the air to

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